Birmingham Collection

By Jasmine Mans and Dominique Christina

Birmingham Girl by Jasmine Mans (Pg 81-82)

Mama said the bomb wasn't meant for me,

I think it was meant for Pastor Martin

Because he be having them dreams

Maybe those white men didn't know

That little black girls be going to church too

And we be folding our hands,

Praying, and taking communion

Just like their daughters do

INTRODUCTION

It was a sunny, September Sunday in Birmingham Alabama. The children of the 16th Street Baptist Church, dressed in their Sunday best, were in charge of the lesson that morning -- "A Love that Forgives." The sermon was based on Luke 23:34: "Then Jesus said, 'Father, forgive them; for they know not what they do'." But before the lesson ever began, a dynamite blast ripped through the congregation, claiming the lives of Denise McNair who was only 11 years old, Addie Mae Collins, Carole Robertson and Cynthia Wesley (all 14). In the words of Jasmine Mans from her poem "Birmingham Girl" -- God can't always protect you from the boogieman.

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I was supposed to wear my church shoes

If I listened maybe the bad men would not have came for me.

I knew they matched my dress but they always be hurting my feet.

I be wondering if

God christened the bombs that exploded my flesh into sacrifice?

And does anybody be hearing those scriptures

Spoken in tongues

Claiming Christ before everything went boom

Before the smoke and the rubble baptized these collapsing bones

You know these stain glass windows be hiding destruction

I be thinking maybe if they knew

We were like the most beautiful flowers

Right before the wind and the dirt started playing tug of war
With the delicates of our petals.

Mama said one man died for the sins of the entire world,
So how did that man let this church tremble on my soul
I don't remember there being enough
Holy water to stop the burning,
To calm all that smoke.

Mama said some heartbreaks be too hard
To swallow at communion
Some serpents be finding salvation
In baptismal pools
Some church mice be screaming
America's dirty little secrets

Momma told me
Some deaths be too black and white
To be labeled holy
And that some baby dolls are sacrificed
Without permission
Some sacrifice comes without fair warning
God can't always protect you

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From the boogieman
Some baby girls will reach the pearly gates
And not be tall enough
To turn the handle.

Mama would always be saying
Some men will be too guilty
To claim innocence with Christ.
But I didn't . . . do anything
I never wanted . . . to play with the white girls.
I never asked . . . for integration,

I be wondering if God was too busy
Trying to protecting Martin
To think about us
I never asked . . . for his dream
But Momma say his dream be asking for me.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Jasmine Mans
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TRANSITION

Even though the legal system was slow to provide justice, the effect of the bombing of the 16th Street Baptist Church was immediate and significant. Outrage over the death of the four young girls helped build increased support behind the continuing struggle to end segregation—support that would help lead to the passage of both the Civil Rights Act of 1964 and the Voting Rights Act of 1965. In that important sense, the bombing's impact was exactly the opposite of what its perpetrators had intended. Dominique Christina creates another powerful character who describes the attack in "Birmingham Sunday."

Birmingham Sunday by Dominique Christina

I do not know what came a'loose first.

A church ain't made for fallin' in on itself.
You don't build 'em prepared for destruction.
You build 'em thinkin' bout the praise shout,
the hand clap, the open-mouthed communions,
how many choir members can fit in the pulpit,
the pancake breakfast you gon' have in the basement
and the stained-glass Jesus.
Even in Birmingham Alabama 1963,
where you had to account for dynamite.
For the sharp teeth of segregation chewin' through

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waterlogged protest marchers swept
clean off their feet. They fell
like blood-torn right angles to
foamin' at the mouth police dogs,
billy clubs and batons.

But churches ain't made for fallin' down.
And I don't know what came a'loose first,
if the pillars tipped over before the pulpit shuddered
if the windows hung for a moment in their frames
before the terrible speed of shrapnel
got in the way of everything . . .

If you were a colored girl in Birmingham,
you knew how to duck and shrink
how to be a misspelled word,
an incomplete sentence
squelched down to sugar-softened
press-and-curl perkiness.
Their silence was so loud,
their teeth a locked gate.
Their mouths held annual sit-ins
for their flame-red throats,

the sizzle and spill of every unsaid thing.
And it is hard to be so still
with all that playground and star-shine
shimmy in the stretch of our bones,
but on Sundays we get it near right.

The mornings rollout in hot cakes and black coffee.
Daddy is a baritone down the hall singin' hymns,
Mama is fixin' his tie then yellin' bout stockings and
Get on in here and eat before this food gets cold!
And we can wear our hair down.
It will be curled round our ears
and stopped with ribbon.
And the wild hunger of Jim Crow
cannot find you in church.
So we slidin' round the kitchen in
our white shoes without a single scuff,
and your sister gets to dab a little rouge
on her cheeks just on Sundays,
just on Sundays.
And the car ride is a sovereign floating joy
the whole way 'cuz mama can sing

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and she's rollin' that pretty bell-tinkle
soprano out and we pickin' up the chorus
where we can and though
we have to keep tuggin' at our slip
so it doesn't dip below our dress. . .

We are everything new and shiny
that God has ever loved, and deep
and high in our colored girl
sometime-loveliness,
because Jim Crow did not seek you in church.

I don't know what came a'loose first.
But when the choir was singin'
I wish I knew how it would feeeeel to be free . . . *
And you were a wet giggle with your sister
in Sunday school,
The sky fell down and smothered everything.

Ceiling tiles flew like occasional birds,
smacked the walls and smoldered
skulls and incandescent smoke
a wild death for a young girl --

the crackle and pop of spinning fire
that burns everything to cinder.
A valley of broken jawbones
baby teeth scattered like confetti,
a stony, vexing sleep

The sun crazy with shining anyway,
the flesh insulted rubble.
The refugeed clergy diggin' through
the glass and mortar,
Findin' tiny limbs and

The world is a singed skirt.

I don't know what came a'loose first
But it all came a'loose didn't it, Addie and Denise?
Didn't it, Cynthia? Didn't it, Carole?
Didn't it all break a'loose,
didn't it drop the winter in?
Didn't it catch and keep the sky snatched low
by the terrible clang of dynamite?

It's funny. It's a dream. And the dream is a roar.

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And the roar keeps time with dragons.

I don't know what came a'loose first.
Churches ain't for fallin' down.
Colored girls should be safe on Sunday.

No one should offer you a heaven,
no matter how honeyed,
when you had't even had your period yet.
Or been to your first boy/girl dance,
or had the chance to gossip about it the next day
laughin' foot-stop girrrrrrrrrl wait-til-you-hear-this
whimsy
That was STILL your right.
No matter what Jim Crow said . . .

And can't nobody re-flesh those bones.
Your mama will never be the same
pleated skirt or
sometimes silly sista
who could smile with all her teeth . . .
Because somebody lifted a sheet,
and underneath it was your bomb-blasted body

and the world broke open and swallowed her whole . . .

Things come a'loose, fall down and fall apart lawd . . .

The center will NOT hold, but

You hear that?

Just over all that ugly, you hear that?

Past the thunder crack of grief and Go down Moses. . .

You hear that?

Can't no detonated handmade nothing' touch it.

Just over the tracks and down the street a ways,

there is still hide and seek rough and tumble

tag and tea parties. Some little girl is hula hoop

and hopscotch lemon cookie wonderful twirlin'

in her mama's old stitched and restitched skirts.

And she's gon' go to church on Sunday singin'

I wish I knew how . . . it would feeeeeeel to be free . . .*

And mean it.

And mean it.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Dominique Christina
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AWARD HISTORY

CO State Qualifier
KS State Qualifier

**** Music and Lyrics to I Wish I Knew How It Would Feel to Be Free by Nina Simone:***
https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=HDqmJEWOJRI

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